

Deinonychus

dye-NON-ee-cuss



- **When** 115–108 million years ago (Early Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Subtropical swamps and forests
- **Length** 10 ft (3 m)
- **Diet** Flesh

Leopard-sized *Deinonychus* (“terrible claw”) is famous for its large toe claws. As in other dromaeosaurs, the claws flipped up off the ground when it was walking in order to stay sharp. Some experts think *Deinonychus* used its toe claws to slash the throat or belly of prey while kicking violently. Others think the claws were climbing aids in juveniles or used for clinging to prey. A stiff tail provided balance when leaping or climbing.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Long, birdlike feathers on the arms, legs, and tail; downy feathers on body
- Sickle-shaped claw on second toe
- Long arms that fold against the body like wings

When

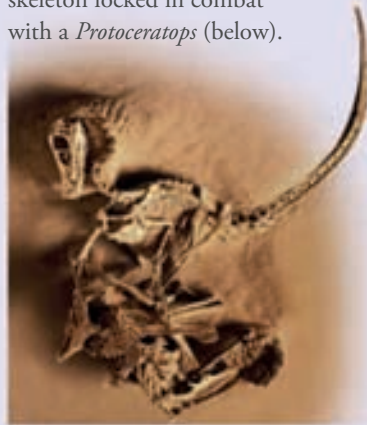
Dromaeosaurs appeared in the Jurassic, 167 million years ago, and died out at the end of the Cretaceous, 65 million years ago.

Velociraptor

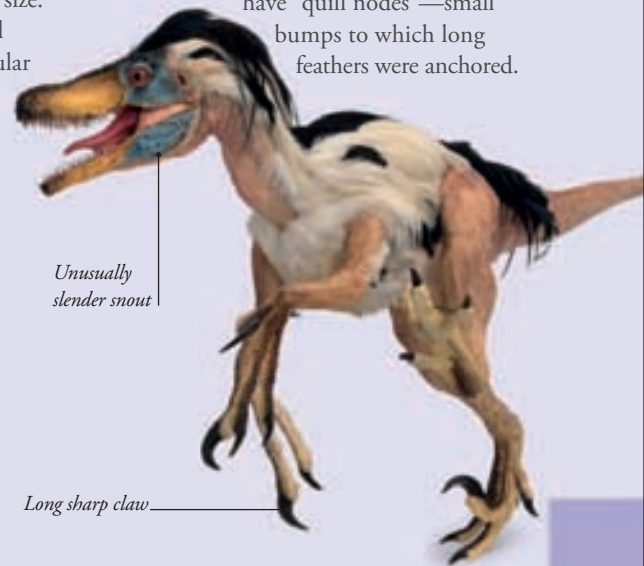
vel-OSS-ee-rap-tor

- **When** 85 million years ago (Late Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** Mongolia
- **Habitat** Scrubland and deserts
- **Length** 6½ ft (2 m)
- **Diet** Lizards, mammals, small dinosaurs

Velociraptor played a starring role in *Jurassic Park*, where it was shown as twice its actual size. In reality it was a slender, feathered animal about the size of a wolf. The most spectacular fossil of *Velociraptor* is a complete skeleton locked in combat with a *Protoceratops* (below).



They died in midfight, perhaps buried by a sudden sandstorm. Like other dromaeosaurs, *Velociraptor* had huge, flickable toe claws and long, clawed arms that unfolded like wings to grapple prey. Although no feathered fossils of *Velociraptor* have been found, its arm bones have “quill nodes”—small bumps to which long feathers were anchored.



Bambiraptor

BAM-bee-rap-tor

- **When** 75 million years ago (Late Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** N. America
- **Habitat** Woodland
- **Length** 2 ft (6 m)
- **Diet** Flesh

In 1995, 14-year-old Wes Linster was hunting for fossils with his parents in the mountains of Glacier National Park in Montana. He was thrilled to find parts of a skeleton. Later excavation revealed that Wes had found a tiny but perfectly preserved dromaeosaur. Because

of its size, scientists named it after the Disney character Bambi the deer. *Bambiraptor* was birdlike and probably feathered, with long hindlimbs that suggest it was a fast runner. It probably hunted small mammals and reptiles, snatching them in its clawed hands as a cat catches a mouse. It had a very large brain relative to its body size, suggesting it was a quick-witted animal (or an infant). Some scientists think its small size allowed it to climb trees.

